

And I can see my mother draining the fat from the pan into the drip pot.

Wait . . . what?

Uh-huh. That's right. My mother was a recycler—of fat.

Yes, fat.

Look, I've managed to block this out of my mind for 25 years, but I remember seeing Mum drain the fat drippings from her cooking into a big metal tin which she kept in the pantry to harden and use later.

And every so often, my sister and I would lift the lid and stare at the murky, hardened fat—daring each other to touch it.

Looking back, there was enough cholesterol in that tin to kill a donkey.

Was cooking oil that expensive in the eighties? Or was Mum trying to infuse the remnants of last Thursday's roast lamb into this week's bangers and mash?

I'm pretty sure it was the former, because in all the years I've been watching *MKR* I've never seen anyone bust out a drip pot. (And let's be honest, Paleo Pete is all over caveman cuisine, so if he's not suggesting contestants serve up bread and dripping then my guess is that dripping is done, baby.)

Anyway, I remember one time when I had a mate come over after school and stay on for dinner.

'Your family's weird,' he told me at school the next day.

My first thought was that he'd seen the drip pot.

Not so.

Rather, he explained that each night at his home he'd eat his dinner on his lap, by himself, watching the TV.

Our family dinner, by contrast, was 'weird'.

We ate in the kitchen, at the (laminex) dining table, set with a tablecloth.

The entire family was seated.